and a better life to the young people. … We want to be builders of our new house of peaceful work and militant humanity!’

28

That night, FDJ lads carried life-size cardboard portraits of Pieck and his SED co-chairman Otto Grotewohl, the new Prime Minister, who declared that friendship with the Soviet Union was the greatest guarantee of peace: ‘It will be the basis of our foreign policy. The government is willing to have friendly relations with all countries which desire them on a basis of equality’.29

By this point, Pieck was well into his seventies and content with fulfilling a patriarchal role with little power. Western journalist Michael Gray acidly observed that the old man pottered around on his farm, occasionally attended press interviews, and his speeches were read by an assistant, ‘while he himself dozes off gently’.30 Grotewohl, like Pieck, did not enjoy good health and within a year, his power was reduced as the SED restructured along more orthodox Soviet lines by electing a Central Committee, a Secretariat and a Politburo, a structure identical to the former KPD.31 Ultimately, Walter Ulbricht, as First Secretary of the Politburo, would hold the keys to power.

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* The principal policy-making and executive committee of the SED.